Jan Pfänder

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Positions

Swiss Federal Institute of Aquatic Science and Technology (Eawag) — Zurich, Switzerland
Postdoctoral researcher — Sep 2025 – present
- Advisor: Viktoria Cologna

ETH Zurich — Zurich, Switzerland
Lecturer — Sep 2026 – present

Cambridge University — Cambridge, UK
Visiting Researcher — May 2026 – Jun 2026
- Host: Sander van der Linden

Education

PhD **École Normale Supérieure (ENS-PSL), Institut Jean Nicod**, Psychology — Paris, France, 2022 – 2025
- Supervisors: Hugo Mercier & Kevin Arceneaux
- Thesis: Essays on Understanding Trust in Science

MA **École Normale Supérieure (ENS-PSL)**, Cognitive Science — Paris, France, 2020 – 2022
- Supervisor: Hugo Mercier
- Thesis: Can we infer people are accurate and competent merely because they agree with each other?

MA **Universität Freiburg**, Journalism (1st year) — Freiburg, Germany, 2019 – 2020

BA **Universität Konstanz**, Political Science and Public Administration — Konstanz, Germany, 2014 – 2018

Work Experience

Direction Interministérielle de la Transformation Publique (DITP) — Paris, France
Research Intern — Jun 2021 – Aug 2021

Assemblée Nationale — Paris, France
Parliamentary Assistant — Sep 2018 – Jul 2019

University of St. Gallen — St. Gallen, Switzerland
Research Assistant — Jun 2017 – Jul 2018

Publications

Peer-reviewed publications
(*n* = 6)

Global Studies on Trust in Science Suggest New Theoretical and Methodological Directions 2026
J. Pfänder, N. G. Mede, V. Cologna
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2025.102215 (Current Opinion in Psychology)

Sciences Perceived as Precise and Consensual Are More Trusted 2026
J. Pfänder, H. Mercier
https://doi.org/10.1177/09636625261471051 (Public Understanding of Science)

How Wise Is the Crowd: Can We Infer People Are Accurate and Competent Merely Because They Agree with Each Other? 2025
J. Pfänder, B. de Courson, H. Mercier
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2024.106005 (Cognition)

Quasi-Universal Acceptance of Basic Science in the United States 2025
J. Pfänder, L. Kerzreho, H. Mercier
https://doi.org/10.1177/09636625251364407 (Public Understanding of Science)

Spotting False News and Doubting True News: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis of News Judgements 2025
J. Pfänder, S. Altay
https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-024-02086-1 (Nature Human Behaviour)

Trusting But Forgetting Impressive Science 2025
J. Pfänder, S. de Rouilhan, H. Mercier
https://doi.org/10.1163/15685373-12340227 (Journal of Cognition and Culture)

Conference proceedings
(*n* = 1)

How Wise Is the Crowd: Can We Infer People Are Accurate and Competent Merely Because They Agree with Each Other? 2024
J. Pfänder, B. de Courson, H. Mercier
escholarship.org/uc/item/4ms2n8wd (Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society)

Large collaborations (minor role)
(*n* = 3)

Investigating the Analytical Robustness of the Social and Behavioural Sciences 2026
B. Aczel, B. Szaszi, H. T. Clelland, …, **J. Pfänder**, … et al.
https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-025-09844-9 (Nature)

Trust in Scientists and Their Role in Society across 68 Countries 2025
V. Cologna, N. G. Mede, S. Berger, …, **J. Pfänder**, … et al.
https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-024-02090-5 (Nature Human Behaviour)

Perceptions of Science, Science Communication, and Climate Change Attitudes in 68 Countries – the TISP Dataset 2025
N. G. Mede, V. Cologna, S. Berger, …, **J. Pfänder**, … et al.
https://doi.org/10.1038/s41597-024-04100-7 (Scientific Data)

Working papers
(*n* = 2)

[Preregistration] Megastudy Testing 20 Information Interventions to Strengthen Trust in Climate Scientists in the US 2026
J. Pfänder
https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20160212

The Rational Impression Account of Trust in Science 2025
J. Pfänder, H. Mercier
https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/nwka2_v1

Grants

Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF) exchange grant 2026
Research visit to Cambridge University (host: Sander van der Linden), 5'000 CHF

Presentations

Invited talks

Strengthening Trust in Climate Scientists in the US - A Megastudy Approach 2026
Max Planck Institute for Human Development, Berlin

Trust in science 2025
Paris School of International Affairs (Sciences Po), Paris

Conference presentations

How different demographic groups respond to interventions aimed at increasing trust in climate scientists 2026
54th DGPs Congress (German Psychological Society), Luxembourg

Alienation and Trust in Climate Scientists in the United States 2026
Workshop 'Knowing how to know in a complex world: Philosophical and empirical perspectives' (LMU Munich), Munich

Trusting but forgetting impressive science 2026
EASP General Meeting, Strasbourg

Strengthening Trust in Climate Scientists in the US - A Megastudy Approach 2026
EASP Small Meeting, Hohenheim

Predicting the effects of a megastudy with behavioral clones 2026
Behavioral Clones Workshop (Max Planck Institute for Human Development), Berlin

Belief in & interventions against misinformation 2025
15th Annual Conference of the European Political Science Association, Madrid

The rational impression account of trust in science 2025
Explaining culture: an interdisciplinary approach, Paris

Spotting False News and Doubting True News. A Meta-Analysis of News Judgments (Keynote) 2025
Infox sur Seine, Paris

How wise is the crowd: Can we infer people are accurate and competent merely because they agree with each other? (Poster) 2024
46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Rotterdam

Processus sous-tendant la confiance dans la science 2024
5ème édition des Rencontres Jeunes Chercheur·euse·s, Grenoble

Spotting False News and Doubting True News: A Meta-Analysis of News Judgments 2024
EDMO Scientific Conference on Disinformation, Amsterdam

Teaching

Courses

The Psychology of Climate Change Communication: theoretical insights and practical applications [website] 2026
ETH Zurich
- Co-taught with Viktoria Cologna
- 24.5h in-class per semester (14 weekly sessions)

Introduction to Research Design [website] 2022 – 2025
Université PSL (Paris Sciences & Lettres)
- Sole instructor & creator of the course
- 30h in-class per semester; one semester a year

Workshops

Meta-analysis for beginners 2024
Laboratoire de Psychologie du Développement et de l'Éducation de l'Enfant (LaPsyDÉ)

Advising

Graduate students
- Pauline Barsky (2026)
- Lou Kerzreho (2023)

Undergraduate students
- Mateo Pivert (2024)
- Ludivine Million (2024)
- Prune Lefevre Jachimowicz (2024)
- Kevin Chen (2023)
- Théodore Lellouche (2022)

Professional Service

Peer Reviewing
(n = 14)
- Journals: *Public Understanding of Science* (3), *Journal of Environmental Psychology* (2), *Artificial Intelligence Review* (1), *Behavior Research Methods* (1), *Društvena istraživanja* (1), *Educational Research*

Review (1), *Nature Climate Change* (1), *Nature Communications* (1), *PNAS Nexus* (1), *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* (1), *Social Science & Medicine* (1)

Summer Schools

Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute St. Andrews, UK
Hosted by the University of St. Andrews, organized by Indiana University Bloomington 2024

Skills

Languages: German, English, French, Spanish

Programming: R, Git (basics), Python (rudimentary)